otherwise, those with a similar outlook and shared values tend to congregate together. But when the entire region grapples with new issues and different capacities, then those inclinations become stronger.

At the heart of the Quad, however, is a level of comfort generated by a marked improvement in multiple sets of relationships. This is enhanced by a stronger sense of common purpose in the face of regional and global challenges. Obviously, the collective ease is based on shared interests and some similar characteristics. But all of this also happened because the resistance to reforming international organizations and limitations of regional ones compelled a search for practical solutions. They, in essence, made the case for the Quad.

A TALE OF THREE TIES

The origins of the Quad actually go back to the coordination among the same four countries who responded to the 2004 tsunami in the Indian Ocean. Subsequent conversations led to a diplomatic gathering of their representatives in 2007. This did not progress further as none of the participants were really prepared to invest sufficient political capital in the initiative at that point of time.

The natural question, therefore, is what changed between 2007 and 2017 when the Quad, now in a more serious incarnation, assembled in New York. The current Quad did not come out of nowhere. It was an accumulated product of multiple developments, among them the complementary capabilities of key players, a more integrated arena and a greater openness to look beyond orthodox constructs.

But the real shift was in the enormous progress that some of the relevant bilateral ties had made in this very decade. The other three nations already had strong relationships with each other, though these too deepened discernibly in this period. What they did not have in 2007 was the degree of convergence and cooperation with India, which they had attained by 2017. Equally important was a leadership in our country that did not subject its national interests to the test of ideological preference.

This was particularly notable in regard to ties between India and the US. Those with Japan followed some distance behind. There was admittedly a greater time lag with Australia, since ties with India warmed up only after the 2014 political changes. It is in the story of these changed relationships